

was free. And China changed into whatever the hell it is, an ostensibly Communist state with dozens of Chinese companies lining up to do public offerings in the West with the hope of one day being listed on the New York Stock Exchange. Whatever you call it, it ain't Mao Tse-tung.

Western Europe has been kept busy privatizing. With Great Britain leading the way, countries have been selling off their steel companies and phone companies and gasworks and insurance companies and big banks—not necessarily because they became born-again capitalists, but because those enterprises were so bureaucratic and inefficient they were breaking the national budgets. At the same time, some Latin American countries have gone from backward, problem areas to exemplars of high growth.

The entire world, in short, unwound all the changes that had started in 1917, when all the clever folks were high on socialism, determined to put more and more economic decisions under state control. Mankind made a complete swing in the other direction, releasing enormous amounts of energy.

Nice things are happening as a result. We don't have to worry nearly as much about being blown up by an atomic bomb. Instead of being targets for nuclear missiles, China and Russia have become targets for venture capital. A great many people who have been living in very deprived circumstances are going to live much fuller, more pleasant lives.

We have some new risks as a result, it is true. The risk of small wars has probably increased, because you no longer have dictators to say, "Cool it, guys." So Yugoslavia dissolved into war, and parts of the old Soviet Union announced their readiness to fight for their own sovereignty. I wonder if Iraq would have attacked Kuwait in 1990 if a strong Soviet influence had still been around to say, "We don't think you ought to do this, and we won't support you if you go ahead with it." With Soviet sponsorship gone, the Iraqis realized their weapons systems were going to deteriorate, and if they were